

My Top 3 Cheeses

A concise guide to three world-class cheeses with tasting notes, pairings, and serving tips.

1) Parmigiano Reggiano (Italy)

Style: Hard, cooked/pressed, cow's milk; DOP.

Age sweet spot: 24–36 months.

Flavor profile: Savory, brothy umami with toasted nuttiness; crystals that “crunch” on the tongue. Unmatched versatility—spectacular for eating on its own and transformative in cooking.

Drinks: Lambrusco secco, Barolo/Brunello, Champagne, amontillado sherry.
Food: 12- to 25-year balsamic vinegar, pears, prosciutto, walnuts.

Serve: Room temp; shave or crumble into bite-sized nuggets.

Kitchen uses: Finishing pastas/soups, pesto, risotti; simmer the rind in stocks.

2) Comté AOP (France)

Style: Alpine, cooked/pressed, cow's milk.

Age sweet spot: 18–24 months (fruitier at 12–18; nuttier and deeper at 24+).

Flavor profile: Hazelnut, brown butter, sweet cream, roasted onion; long, elegant finish.
Versatility: All-purpose greatness—equally superb for snacking and pairings.

Drinks: Jura Chardonnay or Savagnin (vin jaune), dry cider, pilsner, lighter reds (Gamay/Pinot Noir).
Food: Caramel apples, nougats, country bread, smoked ham.

Serve: Room temp; thin slices or small cubes.

Kitchen uses: Gratins, French onion soup, croque-monsieur, fondue blends.

3) Roquefort AOP (France)

Style: Blue, uncooked/pressed, sheep's milk; cave-aged in Combalou.

Age sweet spot: 3–6 months.

Flavor profile: Spicy-saline blue veining balanced by sheep's milk sweetness; creamy, luscious texture.

Why it's top-tier: The benchmark blue—intense yet balanced; transcendent with the right pairing.

Drinks: Sauternes or other late-harvest dessert wines, tawny Port, oloroso Sherry. Honey, ripe figs, toasted walnuts, steak with pan juices.

Serve: Slightly cool (not cold); spread on warm baguette or crumble lightly. Kitchen uses: Salad dressings, compound butter for steaks, sauces for endive/pear.

Buying & Serving Tips

Let cheese sit at room temperature 45–60 minutes before serving.

Buy in wedges, not pre-grated; wrap in cheese paper or parchment plus loose foil; avoid plastic (30–45 g) per person per cheese on a board.

Quick Pairing Cheat Sheet

Parmigiano Reggiano !' Lambrusco + aged balsamic

Comté !' Jura white + apples + cornichons.

Roquefort !' Sauternes + honey + walnuts.

Enjoy!